in them, but manifest to everybody'. Mentioning them, he feels, 'sounds like a satire'. For instance:

> The Hindus believe that there is no country but theirs, no nation like theirs, no kings like theirs, no religion like theirs, no science like theirs. They are haughty, foolishly vain, self-conceited, and stolid. They are by nature niggardly in communicating that which they know, and they take the greatest possible care to withhold it from men of another caste among their own people, still much more, of course, from any foreigner.

Alberuni had, however, begun humbly. 'At first I stood to their astronomers in the relation of a pupil to his master,' he writes. But soon, 'I began to show them the elements on which this science rests, to point out to them some rules of logical deduction and the scientific methods of all mathematics, and then they flocked together round me from all parts, wondering, and most eager to learn from me, asking me at the same time from what Hindu master I had learnt those things'. This really got his goat, and seemed to him illustrative of a broader attitude among the Hindus:

> According to their belief … no created beings besides them have any knowledge or science whatsoever. Their haughtiness is such that, if you tell them of any science or scholar in Khorasan and Persis, they will think you to be both an ignoramus and a liar. If they traveled and mixed with other nations, they would soon change their mind, for their ancestors were not as narrow-minded as the present generation is.

Such 'is the state of things in India', he laments, that Brahmins attempt to combine ideas of purity with the pursuit of science. 'I showed them what they were worth,' he huffs, 'and thought myself a great deal superior to them.' They're 'devoid of training in astronomy, and have no correct astronomical notions. In consequence, they believe that the earth is at rest' (Aryabhata, 500 years earlier, had argued that the earth rotates on its axis daily, a view that had travelled west and had been embraced by Muslim astronomers; smart global opinion posited a spherical earth rotating on its axis in a geocentric universe; however, most Indian astronomers after Aryabhata, including Varahamihira and Brahmagupta, had rejected this theory, and so Indian astronomy had regressed on this major issue).[21] Alberuni translated for them the books of Euclid and Ptolemy's *Almagest* into Sanskrit, and explained how to construct an astrolabe to understand the rotation of the earth. In doing this, he says disarmingly, he was guided only 'by the desire of spreading science'. (Modern scholars too have noted 'the smugly insular stance of Sanskrit scientific literature which, refusing to